

JORVIK & Viking York - Kids

UK Family Tour

The Real Vikings Were Wilder Than the Cartoons

Today is Viking day, and you are standing on the exact ground where they built their greatest city in England. So let's meet them properly, because the cartoons get almost everything wrong. Here is the first surprise. The Vikings were not one country. They were seafaring people from the cold lands we now call Norway, Sweden and Denmark, and it all kicked off on one terrible morning. On the eighth of June, in the year 793, Viking ships came out of nowhere and attacked a peaceful island monastery just up the coast from here, robbing it and terrifying everyone in it. People were so shocked that the news raced across the whole of Europe. And that was only the beginning. Now here is the second surprise, and it is the big one. The Vikings were not just raiders. The very same people were also brilliant traders, explorers and adventurers. In their long wooden ships they sailed almost unbelievable distances. They crossed a whole ocean to Iceland, then to icy Greenland, and then, a thousand years ago, all the way to North America, five hundred years before a man named Columbus. They rowed rivers deep into Russia. A few even ended up guarding an emperor in a faraway golden city. And right here in York, they did not just attack and leave. They stayed, and built a busy, crowded, smelly, wonderful city called Jorvik. In a moment you will ride straight through it. But first, one fact you can bust today with total confidence. Those horns on the Viking helmet in every cartoon? Completely made up. Not one single real Viking ever wore them. Keep that ready, because the museum is about to prove it.

How Far Did the Vikings Really Go?

Let's play a game of just how far. When you think Viking, you probably think of a fierce warrior with an axe. And sometimes, yes. But here is a secret about the word itself. Viking was not the name of a country, or even a kind of person. In their language, going viking meant going off on a raiding trip in a boat. So being a Viking was more like a job you went and did than who you were, and most people back home in Scandinavia were not raiders at all. They were farmers and fishers who stayed put. But the ones who did climb into the ships went to unbelievable places, and it was all thanks to their amazing boats. A Viking longship was long and thin and light, so it could ride across a stormy ocean and then slide right up onto a beach, or up a shallow river, where no other ship could follow. With boats like that, where did they go? Hold on tight. They sailed west to a cold island called Iceland, then to an even colder one they cheekily named Greenland, and then, around a thousand years ago, they crossed the whole Atlantic Ocean and stepped onto North America. That is Canada. Five hundred years before the explorer Columbus, whom your schoolbooks might call the man who found America, the Vikings had already been there. They went east too, rowing rivers deep into the land we now call Russia. And a few of them travelled so unbelievably far south that they ended up standing guard for an emperor in a great golden city, the place we now call Istanbul. Now think about that for a second. The very same people. Some robbing a church in England, some guarding an emperor thousands of miles away, some chopping wood in Canada. Not bad at all for a bunch of farmers with really, really good boats.

You Speak Viking Every Day

Ready for something spooky? You have been speaking Viking words your whole life, and nobody ever told you. Here is how it happened. When the Viking army beat the local kings, the Vikings did not just grab the treasure and sail away. They stayed for good. They shared out the land, married local people, had children, and farmed the fields. So much of England ended up under Viking rule that it got its own special name, the Danelaw, which just means the part of the country where Viking law was in charge instead of English law. And guess which city was the capital of it all. This one. Jorvik, right under your feet. Now for the spooky part. When two groups of people live all mixed up together like that, sharing streets and markets and families, their languages get mixed up too. So little bits of Viking got stuck inside English, and they never came out again. When you say the word sky, that is a Viking word. Egg? Viking. Knife, skin, leg, all Viking. Even the word window is Viking, and it is a good one, because it comes from two Norse words that together mean wind-eye. A window really was an eye for the wind to peek through, back before there was glass. And here is the wildest one of all. The tiny everyday words they, them and their came from the Vikings too. Those are words you use in almost every single sentence you ever say. There is a game you can play from the train window as well. Any town whose name ends in the sound -by, like Whitby or Grimsby, was named by Vikings, because -by was their word for a village. So keep your ears and your eyes wide open today. The Vikings left this place more than a thousand years ago. But little pieces of them are still hiding inside your own mouth, every single time you talk.

How Do We Even Know This?

Here is a question you should always ask about the past. How does anyone actually know? For a very long time, the stories about Vikings came from just two kinds of people, and both of them stretched the truth. First, the monks and priests the Vikings robbed. They were so frightened and so angry that they made the Vikings sound like monsters straight out of a nightmare, all blood and fire. Can you blame them? Second, the Vikings' own storytellers, who told grand, exciting tales of gods and giants and heroes around the fire. Those tales are brilliant, but they were a bit like a superhero movie about your great-great-great-grandparents, made up hundreds of years later. Very exciting. Not exactly true. So who tells the real story of everyday Viking life, the ordinary stuff? The ground does. Right here in York, the dirt under this street kept Viking things safe and hidden for a thousand years, until archaeologists finally dug them up and got to see how real Vikings truly lived. And that is the amazing thing you are about to notice on the ride. Watch very carefully as your time car rolls through the street. You will not mostly see battles and warriors. You will see people working and cooking and making things, dyeing wool into bright colours, carving cups, mending shoes, feeding their animals, and yes, sitting on the toilet. That is the real Jorvik. The true one. The one the scared monks and the boasting storytellers both left out. You are about to see the Vikings not as a scary legend, but as they really were, on an ordinary, busy, smelly day. Keep your eyes wide open.

The Vikings Are Coming — And Staying

On the first of November, 866, York's people were celebrating All Saints' Day when a Viking army — the Great Heathen Army, which is what people actually called it — swept into the city and took it. But here's the twist most people don't know: the Vikings didn't just raid and leave. They liked York. They stayed, settled down, and turned it into Jorvik, one of the richest trading cities in Europe. For nearly a century, York was ruled by Viking kings with fantastic names — the last one was Eric Bloodaxe, who sounds terrifying and was. Viking Jorvik was crowded, busy and international: archaeologists have found silk from Central Asia, coins from Samarkand, amber from the Baltic, and a cowrie shell from the Red Sea — all in the mud of York. Down at the JORVIK Centre, you'll ride a slow "time car" through a rebuilt Viking street from exactly one thousand years ago, with houses, workshops, voices speaking Old Norse — and smells. Yes, real, engineered smells: woodsmoke, fish, leather, and the unmistakable whiff of the Viking toilet pit. The faces of some figures were even reconstructed from real Viking skulls found right here. And remember: this isn't a made-up street. It's built exactly where the real one stood, based on what came out of the ground beneath your feet.

Related listening: The museum's buried ship and walrus-ivory chessmen set the stage for Viking York. Listen back — "Treasure Hunt: A Ghost Ship and a Chess Army" (British Museum, Day 5).

The Great Horned Helmet Lie

Here is one of the biggest fibs in all of history, and today you get to bust it. Vikings did not wear horns on their helmets. Not one. Never. If you look around the JORVIK galleries, and later at a helmet called the Coppergate Helmet in the Yorkshire Museum across town, you will not find a single horn, because horns on a battle helmet would be a terrible idea. Imagine swinging a heavy axe at someone whose helmet has two handy handles sticking out, perfect for grabbing, twisting, and knocking his head sideways. No warrior would do that on purpose.

Real Viking helmets were simple, strong iron caps, round like a bowl, sometimes with a bar to guard the nose and eyes. In fact, in all the digging that has ever been done, archaeologists have found only one helmet complete enough to rebuild from the whole Viking age, pieced back together from rusty fragments found on a farm in Norway. One. And it has no horns.

So where did the horns come from? From the theatre. Almost nine hundred years after the Vikings, in the eighteen seventies, a German artist named Carl Emil Doepler designed the costumes for a giant, booming set of operas by the composer Richard Wagner, full of gods and heroes and doom. He gave some of the characters helmets with horns and wings to make them look wild and ancient and dramatic on stage. The audiences loved it. Painters copied it, then storybooks copied the paintings, then cartoons copied the storybooks, and before long every picture of a Viking, everywhere, had horns. A costume designer basically invented the look of the Viking in an afternoon, and the whole world believed him.

Here is the funny part. There are a few really old horned helmets from Scandinavia, but they come from more than a thousand years before the Vikings, back in the Bronze Age, and they were not for fighting at all. They were special objects for ceremonies, probably worn by priests, and only a couple of people ever wore them. The Vikings never saw them either.

So next time you spot a cartoon Viking with big curly horns, you can say, with total confidence, nope. The real Vikings who walked the streets right here under your feet wore plain iron caps, or often no helmet at all, just a wool hat and a stubborn attitude. The horns are pretend. You know the truth now.

A Day on a Viking Street

Close your eyes for a second and put yourself on the real Coppergate, one thousand years ago. You wake up in a house made of woven wooden sticks packed with mud and moss, with a roof of straw or wooden shingles, and a fire smoking in the middle of the floor. There is no chimney, so the smoke just drifts up and out through the roof, and everything, including you, smells of woodsmoke all the time. It is dark inside, and a bit crowded, because your whole family sleeps on benches along the walls, maybe with a dog and some chickens for company.

Step outside and the street is buzzing. Coppergate is narrow and muddy, lined with fences and workshops, and the neighbours are noisy. Next door someone is hammering hot metal. Across the way a woman is carving combs out of deer antler, and further along a man is spinning wooden cups on a foot-powered machine, which is exactly how the street got its name. You can hear geese honking, pigs snuffling, people haggling, and a language called Old Norse, the great-great-grandparent of modern Icelandic, being shouted and laughed all around you.

Down by the river Ouse, boats are unloading. Some carry fish and firewood from nearby, but others have come a very long way, and this is the amazing part. Traders in Jorvik got their hands on silk from thousands of miles east, golden amber from the cold Baltic Sea, and once even a little cowrie shell that lives only in warm seas near Arabia. A Viking child in muddy York might hold a shell that had travelled further than anyone they would ever meet.

What did you do all day? If you were a Viking kid, you worked. You fetched water, gathered firewood, fed the animals, helped spin wool, and learned a trade from your parents. But there was fun too. Children played with carved wooden toys and little boats, they had ice skates made from horse leg bones for the frozen river in winter, and grownups and children alike loved a board game a bit like chess, where one side defends a king and the other side tries to trap him. And everyone told stories by the fire, long tales of gods and monsters and heroes, because there were no books for most people, only voices and memory.

It was smoky, smelly, freezing in winter and packed with people and animals. But it was also busy, clever, and connected to half the world. That is the street the JORVIK ride is about to carry you through.

The Muddy Miracle Under Your Feet

Why does York know so much about the Vikings? Because of magic mud. In 1976, before a shopping center was built at Coppergate — “street of the cup-makers” in Old Norse — archaeologists got five years to dig. What they found amazed the world. The ground here is wet, oxygen-poor clay, and things that normally rot away — wood, leather, cloth, plants, even insects — had survived for a thousand years. The archaeologists found entire Viking house walls still standing waist-high, fences, workshops, forty thousand objects in all: shoes, socks, combs carved from antler, ice skates made of horse bones, board games, padlocks, pans — the complete everyday life of ordinary Viking families, not kings. They even found thousand-year-old fleas, and eggs of the stomach worms that lived inside actual Vikings, which tells scientists the Vikings had... pretty rumibly tummies. The dig became famous; thousands of people queued to watch. When it ended, York built the JORVIK Centre right on top, and in the glass-floored gallery you can look down at some of the real preserved timbers, exactly where they were found. Archaeologists say a single cubic meter of Coppergate mud holds more history than a treasure chest of gold. Though they would probably also accept the gold.

The Helmet at the Bottom of the Pit

Of all the forty thousand things dug up around here, one is so special it lives in a glass case of its own in a museum across the city. It is a helmet, and the story of finding it is pure luck and pure drama.

It was the twelfth of May, nineteen eighty-two, in the afternoon. The archaeologists had finished part of the dig, and a big mechanical digger was scooping out soil to make room for the new building. Suddenly the metal bucket clanged against something hard, deep down in what had once been a well or a pit. The digger driver stopped. Down in the mud was a lump of rusty metal, and when the archaeologists rushed over and cleaned it, their jaws dropped. It was a helmet, and not a Viking one. It was even older, made by the Anglo-Saxon people who lived in York before the Vikings arrived, more than twelve hundred years ago.

This helmet is a masterpiece. It is made of iron, with strips of shiny brass, and a curtain of tiny iron rings, called mail, to protect the neck. It has guards for the cheeks, a bar to guard the nose, and two beautiful brass eyebrows that meet in a little animal head. Best of all, running over the top is a strip of brass with words scratched into it, in Latin, a prayer that names a man called Oshere. Nobody knows exactly who Oshere was, but this was almost certainly his helmet, worn or owned by a real Anglo-Saxon warrior with a real name. That is incredibly rare. In more than a thousand years of digging all over England, only a tiny handful of helmets this old have ever been found. You could count them on one hand.

Why was such a treasure at the bottom of a pit? That is a mystery. Maybe it was hidden on purpose to keep it safe, and the owner never came back. Maybe it was thrown away, or lost, or dropped in as a gift to the gods. The mud is not telling. But because the ground here is so wet and airless, the same magic that saved the Viking shoes and combs also saved this helmet for us, so that you, today, can look a twelve-hundred-year-old warrior's own helmet right in the eyebrows.

When you have time in York, the helmet is worth hunting down in the Yorkshire Museum. It is one of the greatest things ever pulled out of the ground in this whole country, and a mechanical digger very nearly scooped it up by accident.

The Cleverest Hands in Jorvik

Jorvik was not just a place where Vikings lived. It was a place where they made things, thousands of things, and the mud saved enough of them that we know exactly what the workshops did. This whole street was basically a row of busy little factories run by families.

Start with the name. Coppergate has nothing to do with the metal copper. In Old Norse it means the street of the cup-makers, and sure enough, archaeologists found piles of wooden cores, the leftover middles from spinning bowls and cups on a lathe. A lathe is a machine that turns a lump of wood round and round while you carve it, and the Jorvik cup-makers worked theirs with their feet, shaping smooth wooden bowls all day long.

Then there were the comb-makers, and combs mattered a lot, because almost everyone had head lice and everyone wanted them out. Vikings did not carve combs from wood, which snaps. They used antler, the strong headgear a deer grows and drops every single year, sawn and riveted into beautiful combs with teeth so fine they still work today. Comb-makers were skilled travellers who moved from town to town, and Jorvik kept them busy.

Look closer and the street gets richer still. There were people working amber, that golden see-through stuff that is really tree sap turned hard as stone, carving it into beads and pendants. There were people cutting shiny black jet, a stone from the Yorkshire coast, into rings and lucky charms. There were metalworkers melting silver and bronze to make brooches, pins and coins, and leatherworkers stitching shoes, belts and knife covers. There were spinners and weavers turning sheep wool into cloth, then dyeing it bright colours using plants, red from the roots of a plant called madder, and yellows and blues from others, because Vikings loved colour and were not grey and gloomy at all.

Here is what is wonderful about all this. Kings and battles get remembered, but a whole city actually runs on ordinary skilled people making useful, beautiful things with their hands. Every comb someone lost, every broken cup, every scrap of leather and half-carved lump of amber tells us about a real worker who sat right here, one thousand years ago, concentrating hard, being good at their job.

So as you go round, look for the everyday objects, the combs and cups and beads and shoes. Each one had a maker. And thanks to the magic mud, we can still admire their work, long after their names were forgotten.

The Dig Everyone Came to Watch

Imagine a giant muddy hole in the middle of a busy city, with archaeologists down inside it on their knees, scraping at the ground with little trowels. Now imagine a queue of people, hundreds of them, stretching all the way down the street, waiting patiently in the rain, just to stand and watch those archaeologists dig. That really happened, right here, and it is one of the best parts of this whole story.

The man in charge of the dig was called Richard Hall. Back in the nineteen seventies, when archaeologists found something exciting, they usually hid it away behind big fences so nobody could see, and only clever professors were allowed near. Richard Hall thought that was silly. He said something brave. He said the Vikings of York do not belong only to professors, they belong to everybody, especially to the ordinary people of York. So instead of hiding his dig, he built special platforms where anyone could come and look right down into the hole and watch the Viking city being uncovered, bucket by bucket, day by day.

And people came. Oh, they came. Over the five years of digging, more than one million visitors queued up to watch. One million. The newspapers gave it a nickname, the Viking Dig, with capital letters, like the name of a film, and it became famous all over the country. Children came on school trips and pressed their faces to the railings. Grown-ups came on their lunch breaks. Everybody wanted to see a real Viking shoe or a real Viking comb come out of the mud for the very first time in a thousand years.

Here is why that matters. When Richard Hall saw how much people loved watching, he had an idea. What if, when the digging finished, they did not just fill the hole back in? What if they built something on top so that visitors could keep coming, forever, and travel back to the Viking street whenever they liked? That idea became the JORVIK Centre. The ride you are about to go on exists because a million people once queued in the rain to watch some archaeologists dig a hole. So really, you are here today because those people could not look away. And honestly, neither could anyone. Who would?

The Most Famous Poo in the World

You knew this was coming. JORVIK's most celebrated treasure — genuinely, scientifically celebrated — is a fossilized Viking poo. It's called the Lloyds Bank Coprolite, because it was found in 1972 under the site of a Lloyds Bank branch, and it is magnificent: about twenty centimeters long, the largest fossilized human dropping ever found. Scientists have studied it very seriously, and it's a gold mine of information. From it we know its maker ate mostly meat and bread, not many vegetables — and that they were infested with hundreds of parasitic worms, so their tummy ache was probably historic too. One scientist famously described the coprolite as being as precious, in its own way, as the Crown Jewels — a sentence he must regret at parties. In 2003, disaster struck: the coprolite was dropped during a school visit and broke into three pieces. It was carefully glued back together by experts, which is surely one of the strangest jobs in the history of museum conservation. Find it in its display case and pay your respects. Here's the real lesson hiding in the joke: kings write history books about themselves, but ordinary people leave behind rubbish, lost shoes, and yes, poo — and that's how we truly know how people lived. Science means studying everything. Everything.

What Was for Dinner in Jorvik?

You already know the famous poo tells us what one Viking ate. But scientists have studied seeds, bones, nutshells and rubbish pits from all over Jorvik, so we actually know a huge amount about Viking dinner. And some of it might surprise you.

First, the big rule. There were no potatoes, no tomatoes, no chocolate, no bananas, and no sugar as we know it. All of those come from faraway parts of the world that Europeans had not reached yet. A Viking child would never once have tasted a chip or a piece of chocolate. Imagine that.

So what did they eat? Lots of bread, dark and heavy, made from grain crushed between two big stones. Here is the not-so-tasty part. Little bits of grit from the grinding stones ended up in the flour, so every loaf was slightly gritty, and over a lifetime all that grit wore Viking teeth flat and smooth, like little pebbles. Scientists can often spot a Viking skull just from the worn-down teeth.

They ate meat when they could, beef, pork, mutton and chicken, plus eggs. They ate a lot of fish, both from the river and, more and more as the years went by, from the sea, herring and eel and more. They kept cows and goats for milk, and turned it into cheese and butter. From their gardens and the wild they got cabbages, leeks, onions, peas and beans, and they gathered apples, plums, cherries, blackberries and hazelnuts. For something sweet there was honey, the only sweet treat they had, and it was precious. To drink there was milk, water, and ale, a kind of weak beer, which even children sipped a little of, because it was cleaner than the dirty river water.

And nothing was wasted. Bones were boiled for soup and marrow, then sometimes carved into tools, pins, skates and toys. A Viking kitchen threw almost nothing away, which is lucky for us, because their leftovers and rubbish are exactly how we know all this.

So a Viking feast was hearty, brown and salty, full of bread and meat and fish and ale, sweetened only by honey and berries, and crunchy with just a little too much grit. Delicious, mostly. Hard on the teeth. And absolutely, definitely, no chocolate.

Your Ride Through a Thousand Years

In a few minutes you are going to climb into a little car and ride straight into the past. Before you do, here is what is really going on, because the JORVIK ride is much cleverer than it looks.

The carriages are called time cars, and they carry you slowly through a rebuilt Viking street. But this is not a made-up fairy-tale village. The people who built it used what the diggers found in the ground right here, so the houses stand exactly where real houses stood, the workshops make the things the real workshops made, and even the muddy paths follow the real streets. It is a full-size copy of Jorvik, built on the very spot where Jorvik once stood.

Look at the faces of some of the figures. A few of them were built from real Viking skulls found in York. Scientists can take a skull and, layer by layer, add on where the muscles and skin and nose and lips would have gone, until a real face from a thousand years ago stares back at you. So some of the people you glide past are not invented. They are portraits of actual Vikings who lived and died in this city.

Now, the part everyone talks about. The smells. As you ride, you will smell things, and they are there on purpose. Woodsmoke from the fires, fish from the market, leather from the workshops, and, yes, the pong of the toilet pit. The designers really did engineer Viking smells, because your nose remembers things your eyes forget, and they wanted you to feel how a crowded, busy, whiffy city actually felt. Try not to hold your breath. That is the whole point.

Listen too. The voices you hear are speaking Old Norse, the real language of Jorvik, worked out by scholars from old writings. You are hearing, more or less, what these streets actually sounded like.

One more thing to know. This whole ride was underwater not long ago. In December of two thousand fifteen, terrible floods poured into York and swamped the Viking street. The centre had to shut, and clever people spent a year and a half rebuilding it, better than before, adding everything scientists had learned since. Water once buried and saved the real Jorvik in the mud, and water later tried to destroy the copy, and people rebuilt it anyway.

So climb aboard, breathe in, and keep your eyes and ears and nose wide open. You are about to travel one thousand years, and every smelly, noisy, muddy detail is trying to tell you the truth.

The Battle That Ended the Vikings

Here is something amazing that almost nobody knows. The whole Viking age, all three hundred years of it, came to an end just up the road from here, in the fields outside York. On a hot day in the autumn of the year ten sixty-six, an English king and his soldiers fought a huge Viking army beside a little wooden bridge over a river, at a place called Stamford Bridge. And the English won. The Viking king who died that day, a Norwegian giant named Harald Hardrada, is sometimes called the very last Viking. After that battle, no big Viking army ever invaded Britain again. Ever.

So think about what that means. This one city holds both ends of the Viking story. Underneath your feet is where the Vikings settled and built their busy trading town, Jorvik, right at the beginning. And seven miles that way, in an ordinary green field, is where the Viking age finally ran out, at the end. You could ride a bike from one to the other in an afternoon.

And there is one more twist coming, because just three weeks after that battle, on the other side of England, something even more famous happened, and the two events are secretly the same story. Stick with me. It starts with a lonely warrior, an axe, and a bridge.

Related listening: Holy Island, seen from the train, is where the Viking Age began in 793. Listen back — “Crossing into Scotland” (Train to Edinburgh, Day 8). Related listening: 1066 joins them: the Viking Age ended near York the same year the Conqueror’s Tower story began. Listen back — “The White Tower: 950 Years Old” (Tower of London, Day 3).

How the Whole Adventure Started

Before we get to the end of the Vikings, let us go right back to the very beginning, because you have already visited it on this trip without quite realising. Do you remember, on the train on the eighth day, looking out at a low, flat island just off the coast, with the sea washing all around it? That was Lindisfarne, and that little island is where the whole Viking story is said to have begun.

Picture the scene. It is the summer of the year seven ninety-three, more than twelve hundred years ago. On Lindisfarne there is a monastery, a quiet, peaceful place full of monks who spend their days praying and making the most beautiful books in the world, painted with gold and swirling patterns. It is the holiest, safest place anyone can imagine. Nobody would ever dare attack it.

And then, out of the grey sea, come ships. Long, low, fast ships with striped sails and carved animal heads on the front. The Vikings. They leap ashore with axes and swords, and they do something no one thought possible. They rob the holy monastery, they smash and grab all its gold and treasure, they hurt the monks, and they sail away again before anyone can stop them. When the news spread, people all over Europe were absolutely horrified. A famous writer of the time, a man from York funnily enough, wrote a letter saying that never, ever, had such a terror appeared in Britain before. Everyone was asking the same frightened question. Who are these people, and where did they come from, and will they come back?

They came back. That single raid on Lindisfarne was just the very first drop of rain before a huge storm. For the next hundred years the Vikings came again and again, more and more of them, until they stopped just robbing and started staying, and building towns, and one of those towns was Jorvik, right here.

So hold this in your head today. It began with terrifying raiders bursting out of the sea at Lindisfarne, the island you saw from the train. It carried on with clever traders and busy families in the muddy streets under your feet. And, as you are about to find out, it ended with one last enormous battle in a field just

outside this very city. You have seen the beginning and you are standing in the middle, all on the same holiday. Now for the end.

The Man Who Held the Bridge

This is one of the greatest true adventure stories in all of English history, and it happened just outside York, so listen closely.

In the year ten sixty-six, three different men all wanted to be King of England, and they were ready to fight for it. There was Harold, the English king, waiting nervously down south, watching the sea. There was William, a duke from France, building a fleet of ships to invade. And there was Harald Hardrada, the King of Norway, an absolute giant of a man, said to be nearly seven feet tall, who had adventured all the way to the great city of Constantinople and back, and who now sailed up the river to York with three hundred longships to grab England for himself.

At first it went brilliantly for the Vikings. They beat the local soldiers just outside York and marched in like conquerors. But King Harold was cleverer and faster than anyone expected. Way down south, he gathered his best warriors and marched them north at incredible speed, day and night, day and night, all the way up the country, and burst upon the Vikings so suddenly that many of them had left their heavy armour back on the ships, because it was a hot day and they thought they were safe.

And now the famous bit. As the English charged, the Vikings had to get across a narrow wooden bridge, and one single Viking warrior decided to save his friends. He was huge, and he had a great axe, and he planted himself right in the middle of that bridge and would not move. One man, against an entire army. The English came at him and he swung his axe and knocked them down, one after another after another, holding the whole bridge by himself while his friends got ready behind him. The old stories say he cut down as many as forty men before he fell. And how did they finally beat him? A sneaky English soldier floated underneath the bridge in a little barrel, poked his spear up through the gaps in the planks, and got him from below. Not exactly fair, but it worked.

After that the battle was over quickly, and King Harald Hardrada of Norway was killed by an arrow through the throat. The last great Viking army was finished. Of the three hundred ships that had come, so few Vikings were left alive that they only needed about twenty-four ships to sail home.

But here is the sad and astonishing ending. King Harold, the winner, barely had time to celebrate before terrible news arrived. William and his French army had landed in the south. So poor Harold had to turn his tired, wounded soldiers straight around and march all the way back down England again, and just three weeks later he fought William at the Battle of Hastings, and this time Harold lost, and was killed. And William became King of England.

And now the very best secret of all, that ties your whole holiday together. Remember the Tower of London, right at the start of your trip? William built that. And guess where William's family came from, long ago? They were Vikings too. Northmen who had settled in France a few generations earlier and become the Normans. So the Vikings did not really lose in ten sixty-six at all. One set of Vikings was beaten in a field outside York, and another set of Vikings, gone a bit French, won the whole of England and built the Tower where your adventure began. It was Vikings, all the way, from the very first day of your trip to this very last one.

The Sons of Ragnar

You already know that a big Viking army marched in and took York way back in the year eight sixty-six. But who was actually in charge of that army? The old Viking stories give us a wonderful answer, and it comes with one of the best Viking names ever.

The stories say the army was led by a band of brothers, the sons of a famous Viking chief named Ragnar Lothbrok, which means Ragnar Hairy-Breeches, because he supposedly wore funny shaggy trousers into battle. And the most famous brother of all had a name that will give you the shivers. He was called Ivar the Boneless. Nobody today is quite sure why. Maybe he could not walk and was carried into battle on a shield. Maybe he was just amazingly bendy and quick. Either way, Ivar the Boneless and his brothers were said to be the fiercest, cleverest Viking leaders of their whole age, and the stories say they came to England on a mission of revenge, hunting for the king who had killed their dad.

Now, some of that is true history and some of it is a thrilling story the Vikings told each other around the fire hundreds of years later, and it can be tricky to tell which is which. So next let me tell you the legend of what happened to their father Ragnar, and it involves a king, a pit full of snakes, and a very rude last laugh. Ready?

Ragnar and the Snake Pit

Alright, gather round, because this is a proper Viking legend, full of drama. And I am going to be honest with you the whole way through, because a lot of this is a story the Vikings made up, not stuff that really happened. But what a story it is.

Once, so the tale goes, there was a mighty Viking king named Ragnar Lothbrok, and he raided far and wide across the seas, and everyone feared him. But one day his luck ran out. His ship was wrecked in a storm on the coast of northern England, and he was captured by an English king called Ælla. Now, King Ælla knew he had caught somebody famous, and he wanted to make sure everyone remembered it. So he had Ragnar thrown into a deep pit, and the pit was full of poisonous snakes.

And here is the moment that made the story famous forever. As Ragnar lay there among the hissing snakes, he was not afraid. He laughed. And he said a strange and spooky thing. He said, the little piglets would grunt if they knew how the old boar suffered. It was a riddle. The old boar was Ragnar himself. And the little piglets, well, those were his sons. He was warning King Ælla, with his last breath, that his boys were going to come for revenge, and they were going to be furious.

And they were. When Ivar the Boneless and his brothers heard how their father had died, the stories say they gathered the biggest Viking army anyone had ever seen and sailed for England, not to steal treasure and leave, but to conquer the whole place and hunt down King Ælla. And when they finally caught him, the legend says they gave him a truly horrible ending, so nasty that I am not even going to describe it. It has a scary name, the blood eagle, and that is all you are getting.

But now the honest part, because you deserve the truth. Did any of this really happen? Well, there really was a big Viking army, and it really did take York, and there really was a King Ælla who really did die fighting the Vikings near here. Those bits are true. But Ragnar himself might never have been one real person at all, the snake pit is almost certainly a made-up story, and most experts today think the horrible blood eagle was probably invented too, or came from someone misunderstanding an old Viking poem about eagles eating on a battlefield. So it is a brilliant, scary, exciting legend, wrapped around a few real facts, like a spooky story built on top of a real place. And the real place, where the real army really came, is right here, all around you.

Why Every Street Ends in Gate

Here is a game you can play for the rest of the day, and once you know the secret you will spot it everywhere in York. Look at the street signs. Really look at them. Coppergate. Stonegate. Micklegate. Fossgate. Goodramgate. Notice anything? Almost all of them end in the same little word. Gate.

Now, you might think gate means a gate, like a gate in a fence that you swing open. But it does not, and this is the fun part. That word gate is actually a Viking word. In the language the Vikings spoke, the word for a street was gata. So when you say Coppergate, you are really saying Copper Street, and when the Vikings named these streets more than a thousand years ago, that name stuck and never, ever left. Every time you read a street sign ending in gate, you are reading a little bit of Viking language that has survived for a thousand years. Micklegate just means the big street, because mickle was their word for big.

And now the joke that catches everyone out, so see if you can remember it. In York, the streets are called gates. But the actual big stone gateways, the giant doorways in the city walls that you walk through to get into the old city, those are not called gates at all. They are called bars. Bootham Bar. Monk Bar. Micklegate Bar. So in this crazy, wonderful city, the gates are streets, and the bars are gates. Try saying that to a grown-up and watch their face. There is even a real street here with the silliest name in all of England. It is called Whip-Ma-Whop-Ma-Gate, it is the shortest street in the city, and nobody knows for certain what the name means. See if you can find it.

So why did all these Viking words stick around? Because after the Vikings took over, this whole half of England, the whole north and east, was actually run by the Vikings, under Viking rules and Viking law. People even had a name for it. They called it the Danelaw, which just means the law of the Danes, because a lot of the Vikings came from Denmark. For a while it really looked like England might turn into a Viking country for good. It took the English kings almost a hundred years to win it all back, and even after they did, the Viking words were stuck fast, in the streets, in the names, in the way people talked.

So the Vikings never really left York at all. They are hiding in plain sight, on every street sign, in a little word you will now notice everywhere. Gate. Gata. Street. Go on, start counting them.